FREE CARDS

If I Feel Unsafe: Sequence Cards

Six steps in order: notice, say no, go away, tell, keep telling, and know you did the right thing. Cards, scenarios to rehearse and a body warning signs page.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic children and young people, with the parents, carers, teachers and SNAs who support them.

NCCA STAGE
Primary · Junior Cycle · Senior Cycle and LCA

Easy read

I have the right to feel safe. If I feel unsafe, I follow the steps. I tell until someone helps.

How to use this resource

- Print page 2, cut out the six cards and laminate them. Put them in order on a table or wall. Read them together.
- Use page 3 to rehearse the scenarios. Rehearse **when calm**, never in the middle of a worry.
- Page 4 is **My body warning signs**. Colour in where you feel worry, and write your own signs.
- Keep the cards visible. Say the same words at home and at school.

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Version 1.0 · if-i-feel-unsafe-sequence-cards

If I feel unsafe: six steps

Cut out the cards. Put them in order, 1 to 6. Say each step out loud.

1



Notice my body feels worried

My tummy, heart or hands feel strange. That is a warning sign.

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2



Say no or stop

"No." "Stop." I can say it, or put my hand up. My body is mine.

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3



Go away

I move to a safe place. I do not have to stay.

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4



Tell a safe adult

I find a safe adult. "I need to tell you something."

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5



Keep telling until someone helps

If the first adult does not help, I tell another one. I keep telling.

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6



I did the right thing

Telling is brave and right. It is not my fault. I am safe to feel proud.

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I have the right to feel safe.



Nothing is too awful to tell.



I keep telling until someone helps.

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Scenarios to rehearse

Read each situation. Ask: which step am I on? What do I say? Where do I go? Who do I tell? Practise out loud or with cards. There is no wrong answer to "How does my body feel?"

At school, an older pupil touches you in a way you do not like.

Stop. I do not like that. (Walk away. Tell a teacher or SNA.)

At a party, a grown-up wants a hug and you do not.

No thanks. I can wave instead.

Someone says "this is our secret, do not tell".

I do not keep secrets that worry me. I am telling.

Someone online asks for a private photo.

No. (Stop replying. Tell a safe adult.)

You told one adult and they said they were too busy.

I need help. I am telling someone else.

You are on the bus and someone sits too close and touches you.

Stop. Move away. (Move near the driver or other adults. Tell a safe adult.)

You feel worried but cannot say why.

I feel worried. I do not know why. Can I sit with you?

Surprise or secret?

A **surprise** is happy and ends soon, like a birthday present. A **secret** is something you are told not to tell, and it can make you feel worried. We do not keep secrets that make us feel worried or unsafe. We tell.

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My body warning signs

Our bodies give signals when we feel worried or unsafe. Everyone is different. Autistic people may notice some signals less, or in different ways. Tick the ones that are true for you. Add your own.

- ☐ My tummy feels tight, sick or full of butterflies.
- ☐ My heart beats fast.
- ☐ My hands feel sweaty or shaky.
- ☐ My face feels hot, or I go red or pale.
- ☐ I feel frozen and cannot move or speak.
- ☐ My head feels fuzzy, or I cannot think.
- ☐ I want to run away or hide.
- ☐ I feel like crying, shouting or hitting out.
- ☐ I rock, flap, cover my ears or close my eyes more than usual.
- ☐ I feel very quiet, or I cannot find my words.

My own warning signs

When I feel worried, my body: _____

When I feel unsafe, I want to: _____

A safe adult I can tell: _____

Not sure what you feel?

That is okay. Many people are not sure. If your body feels strange, or something does not feel right, you can still follow the steps. You do not need to be sure to tell someone.

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Notes for adults

- **Rehearse under calm conditions.** Learning happens when the child is relaxed. Practise little and often, using role-play, puppets, photos or written scripts. Never test a child by pretending to be unsafe without warning.
- Many autistic children have different body signals (interoception). They may not feel a racing heart or tight tummy until late. Teach signs from outside as well: "I notice you are quiet. Is something wrong?" Add signals they do show.
- Not all children can say no or run away. Freezing is a normal response. Teach other ways: a hand signal, a card, a word, or going to a set place. **Never blame a child who did not say no.**
- Make **telling** easy, and answer it well: stay calm, believe them, thank them, do not promise to keep it secret, and do not ask leading questions. In school, tell the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) the same day. Otherwise contact Tusla. See *Children First* (2017).
- The key messages are: **we all have the right to feel safe**, and **nothing is so awful that we can't talk about it with someone we trust**. If the first adult does not help, the child keeps telling.
- Autistic children are more likely to be targeted by those who exploit trust. Teach that no adult, older child or friend has the right to ask them to keep body-related secrets. Supports never need a diagnosis.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strand **Myself**, strand unit *Safety and protection*; the Stay Safe programme (say no, get away, tell, keep telling).
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 1 **Understanding Myself and Others** and Strand 3 **Relationships and Sexuality**: personal safety and help-seeking.
- Senior Cycle SPHE (new specification published 2024) and LCA Social Education: personal safety.
- Department of Education Wellbeing Policy Statement and Framework for Practice (2018, updated 2019); *Children First* (2017).

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Emergency

112 or 999 — Gardaí, ambulance or fire. Use it if someone is in danger now.

Tusla – Child and Family Agency

Report a worry about a child's safety to your local Tusla social work duty team. Contacts at tusla.ie.

An Garda Síochána

Contact your local Garda station, or 112 or 999 in an emergency. Garda Confidential Line: 1800 666 111.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Text About It

Free text support any time: text HELLO to 50808.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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